

Codebook

Breaking the Spiral of Silence — main experiment

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This codebook documents the variables used by the analysis code, with the question wording and response options taken from Qualtrics.

Identifiers and session variables

Variable	Values	Description
survey_id	1–333 in TC_cleaned, 1–383 in TC_first_movers_merged	Study-local respondent number: the original Xlab/SONA participant numbers were replaced during de-identification.
zoom_id	1–36	Discussion session. Value-labelled with the session's date and time (e.g. 2023/3/13 15:00)
treat	0 = Control, 1 = Treatment	Information-treatment assignment. Missing for first movers.
attr	0 = completed, 1 = attrited	
attendance	1 = attended	1 for the 383 who attended; missing, not 0, for the 71 who did not.
group_size	7–13	Number of participants in the respondent's session.
session_time	1, 2	Which of the two afternoon slots.
moderator	1, 2, 3	Which of the three trained moderators ran the session.
week	0–4	Recruitment round (round 1 = 0).

Private beliefs — private_*

Question. Each of ten statements, presented one per screen: “[statement]” with the instruction that any question may be skipped.

Response options in Qualtrics: Agree (1), Disagree (2).

Recoded to **1 = Agree**, **0 = Disagree**; missing = skipped.

Variable	Statement
private_rename_schools	All public schools named after controversial historical figures, including former Presidents George Washington, Thomas Jefferson, and Abraham Lincoln, should be renamed.
private_affirmative_action	If Proposition 209 was repealed, universities in the UC system should adopt extensive affirmative action policies that explicitly take into account race in the admission process.
private_death_penalty	The U.S. should abolish the death penalty.
private_immunizations	Immunizations, such as for Covid and the flu, should be required on Berkeley’s campus.
private_daylight_saving	Daylight saving time should be eliminated. (<i>placebo</i>)
private_college_require	State government jobs should eliminate college degree requirements. (<i>placebo</i>)
private_trans_athletes	Transgender athletes should be allowed to compete in female sports at the college level.
private_imm_citizenship	The U.S. should create more accessible pathways to citizenship, even for those who arrived illegally.
private_religion_employ	Under the principles of freedom of religion, people have the right to make choices about who they serve or employ based on their religious values.
private_criminalization / private_nv_crimes	Non-violent crimes should be punishable with alternatives to jail.

The Immunizations and Affirmative Action statements were worded in the opposite direction in the first-mover instrument. private_ therefore means the reverse of the second-mover coding on those two topics in first_movers_analysis.dta

Perceived belief distribution — guesses_*

Question. *“Among the other Berkeley students who answer this question in this survey, what percentage do you think will privately answer ‘agree’ and ‘disagree’ with this statement respectively? (please enter integers)”* — entered as two fields, Agree (%) and Disagree (%), constrained to total 100. Incentivised for accuracy under a binarized scoring rule.

As stored: the percentage answering “agree”, 0–100.

Prefix	Elicited at
guesses_b_<topic>	Baseline survey
guesses_m_<topic>	Midline survey, after the information treatment
guesses_e_<topic>	Endline survey, after the Zoom session

Certainty — certain_*

Question. *“How certain do you feel about your guesses above?”*, asked after each guess.

Values: 1 = Certain, 2 = Uncertain. Prefixes follow the guesses_* pattern

Public expression in the Zoom session — e_*

Not a survey item. Recorded by the moderator from the private chat messages participants sent to indicate they wished to speak. The e_* variables in the deposited files contain only 0 and 1. Every analysis script converts missing to 9 at the top (`replace e_'var' = 9 if e_'var' == .`), so the value 9 appears throughout the code and the logs

Value	Meaning
1	Publicly expressed agreement
0	Publicly expressed disagreement
missing	Stayed silent

Endline expression on a further topic — trans_expression

Question. Participants were reminded of the transgender-athletes statement and invited to state their view, told *“your responses will be shared publicly with other study participants”*, with an explicit option to skip.

Values: 1 = Agree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Skip.

Recall of the session — recall_*

Asked at endline, immediately after the session.

Variable	Question
recall_n	<i>"How many students (excluding study moderators) were in the Zoom session?"</i>
recall_<topic>_a	Number who agreed on that topic
recall_<topic>_d	Number who disagreed
recall_<topic>_s	Number who stayed silent
recall_<topic>_s_a	Of those who stayed silent, how many the respondent thinks privately agreed

All are counts entered as integers. recall_<topic>_s against the true number silent in that session is the paper's direct measure of attention to silence.

Demographics

Response options and their numeric codes are exactly as they appear in Qualtrics. Note that several scales skip numbers — this is Qualtrics choice numbering, not a coding error.

gender

1	2	4	5	6
Male	Female	Transgender	Non-binary / non-conforming	Prefer not to say

(3 is unused.)

race — "What is your race and ethnicity?"

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
American Indian or Alaska Native	Asian	Black or African American	Hispanic or Latino	Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander	White	Prefer not to say

year — "Specify your year in college"

1	2	3	4	5	6
Freshman	Sophomore	Junior	Senior	Graduate student	Prefer not to say

major

1	2	7	9	10	11	13	15
Arts-Related	Science and Math-Related	Prefer not to say	Environment-Related	Business-Related	Engineering and Technology	Social Science	Literature and Language

ideology — “...arranged from extremely liberal to extremely conservative. Where would you place yourself on this scale?”

1	2	3	4	5	6	8	9
Extremely Liberal	Liberal	Slightly liberal	Moderate	Slightly Conservative	Conservative	Extremely Conservative	Prefer not to say

(7 is unused)

native_speaker — “Are you a native English speaker?” · 1 = Yes, 2 = No.

Twitter

Variable	Question	Values
twitter_yn	Do you have a Twitter account?	1 = Yes, 2 = No
twitter_time	On average, how much time do you spend on Twitter?	1 = >4 hrs/day, 4 = 3–4 hrs/day, 2 = 1–2 hrs/day, 3 = <1 hr/day, 5 = <1 hr/week, 6 = <1 hr/month, 8 = Prefer not to say
twitter_frequency	On average, how often do you retweet?	1 = A few times per day ... 5 = Almost never, 6 = Prefer not to say
twitter_importance	How important is Twitter in informing your own political views?	1 = Not at all important ... 7 = Extremely important, 8 = Prefer not to say

The self-reported Twitter handle was collected and was removed during de-identification; these behavioural items are retained.

Social appropriateness — norm_*

Elicited from **first movers only**, in a separate survey taken after every other part of the baseline, following Krupka and Weber (2013). Participants rated each statement on a five-point scale and earned a bonus for matching the modal response.

As stored: 1 = Very inappropriate ... 5 = Very appropriate, after the recoding in Table B1.do. Four items — `nv_crimes`, `immunizations`, `religion_employ`, `trans_athletes` — were presented on a reversed scale in Qualtrics and are reversed there ($\text{norm}_v = 6 - \text{norm}_v$).